FREE COURSE

Break Into Product Management

For career switchers without CS degrees or FAANG credentials. Honest frameworks, real templates, and the unspoken truths about what PMs actually do — and how to get hired to do it.

6 modules · ~5 hours of reading · Templates + frameworks · No sign-up required

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Let's start with the thing no one says out loud: the PM hiring process is biased toward people who look like they already are PMs. Engineering background? Recognized MBA? FAANG internship? You get fast-tracked. Everyone else has to be twice as good at the specific thing that matters: demonstrating product thinking.

This course is about building that demonstration. Not faking it — building it. Because if you've been a teacher, a nurse, a retail manager, a journalist, or literally any other profession, you have more real product thinking than you think. You just haven't learned to package and communicate it yet.

That's what we're fixing here. No fluff. No mindset shifts. Real templates, real frameworks, and the actual steps that get people hired.

MODULE I

What PMs Actually Do (Not the Job Description)

- Understand the four actual PM activities that drive outcomes
- Identify the difference between PM at small vs. large companies
- Know which type of PM role fits your background

The job description is a fantasy

Most PM job descriptions list 20 responsibilities. In practice, the role is about 4 things: talking to users to understand problems, making decisions about what to build and in what order, working with engineers and designers to ship something, and measuring whether it worked. That's it.

Everything else — "defines product vision," "drives cross-functional alignment," "communicates with C-suite" — that's what happens when you do those four things well at scale. It's not a separate skill set. It's the output of being good at the core job.

The four things that actually matter

1. User understanding. Not user research as an academic exercise — actually being in the room with people who have the problem you're trying to solve, hearing their language, feeling their frustration, understanding what they already tried. This is the hardest skill to fake and the most important one to develop.

2. Prioritization under pressure. Every PM has more requests than capacity. The skill is not managing everyone's feelings about your roadmap. The skill is making defensible decisions about what gets worked on first, and communicating those decisions in a way that moves forward rather than creating resentment.

3. Writing clearly under ambiguity. PMs write more than any other role on the product team. Specs, updates, briefs, analyses. The ability to take a fuzzy situation and produce a document that gives a team a clear direction — that's a PM's primary output.

4. Cross-functional influence without authority. PMs don't manage engineers or designers. They earn trust and get people to prioritize their work based on the quality of their thinking and their relationships — not their title. This is especially true at larger companies.

Small company vs. large company PM

Small company (under 100 people): You'll do all four things every week. You'll also write your own acceptance criteria, handle customer support when something breaks, and prototype features because there's no designer available. The upside: you see the full feedback loop. You build something, it ships, you watch what happens. The learning velocity is unmatched.

Large company (200+ people): You'll specialize. You might own one metric on one surface of one product. Your days will be meetings. The upside: structure, process, and the ability to learn how high-functioning product orgs operate at scale. The downside: it can take 18 months before you feel like you've actually shipped something.

> CAREER SWITCHER ADVICE
>
> If you're breaking into PM, start at a company with fewer than 200 people. Not because the work is easier — it isn't — but because you'll see more of the job faster. Every week will teach you something that would take 6 months to learn in a large org. Get the reps first. Scale later.

Which PM role fits your background?

- **Growth PM:** Obsessed with acquisition, activation, retention, revenue. If you've worked in marketing, sales ops, or analytics, this is your path.
- **Platform PM:** Builds the infrastructure other teams build on. More technical. Better fit for people with engineering-adjacent backgrounds.
- **Consumer PM:** B2C products, millions of users, design and copy matter enormously. If you've worked in journalism, content, or UX — strong fit.

- **B2B / Enterprise PM:** Customer-facing, relationship-heavy, requirement
  If you came from customer success, account management, or consulting —
  fastest path in.
- **Ops / Internal tools PM:** Often overlooked. Builds tools used by internal teams. Lower glamour, faster hiring, and you'll ship more in year one than most PMs do in three years at a large company.

KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 1

The job description doesn't tell you what the job is. The job is: understand users, prioritize relentlessly, write clearly, and build trust without authority. Everything else follows from those four things.

EXERCISE 1

Write a one-paragraph answer to this question: "What is a problem you've seen users of any product, service, or process experience — and what would you have done differently if you owned that product?" This is the PM interview question. Practice it now. You'll use it in every interview you have.

MODULE 2

Your Non-Traditional Background Is an Advantage

REAL TALK

- Reframe your previous experience as product thinking evidence
- Identify the 3 transferable skills you already have that PMs struggle to develop
- Write your story in PM language without misrepresenting anything

What career switchers get wrong

The most common mistake: trying to minimize your previous career and emphasize your PM-adjacent activities. This is backwards. A hiring manager looking at 50 PM resumes from people who all did the same "I pivoted to PM after my first job" arc wants the person who has something different to say. Your background is the differentiator — as long as you learn to tell the story correctly.

The story isn't "I was a teacher but now I want to be a PM." The story is: "I managed a curriculum for 120 students, which meant I was constantly balancing user research (student feedback), stakeholder communication (parents and administration), and prioritization under resource constraints (32 kids, 45 minutes, one whiteboard). I'm a PM who already has the soft skills — I'm here to learn the craft."

The three skills non-traditional backgrounds develop that PMs struggle to get

1. User empathy without condescension. People who've worked in healthcare, education, social services, or retail have spent years in actual service of other humans' problems. Most CS-to-PM converts have to work hard to develop genuine empathy. You already have it. That's your edge.

2. Communication across wildly different audiences. If you've worked in journalism, teaching, community organizing, or sales, you've developed the ability to take complex information and make it understandable for people who don't share your context. That's 60% of the PM's communication job.

3. Decision-making under ambiguity without data. Most structured engineering or finance roles train people to wait for more information before deciding. PMs almost never have enough information. If you've worked in a role where you regularly had to act on incomplete information — emergency room, courtroom, startup operations, event production — you've built a muscle that matters enormously.

How to translate your background into PM language

The translation is not fabrication. It's reframing what you actually did using vocabulary that makes product teams recognize the skill:

What you did	PM translation
Managed a team of customer support agents	Owned the customer feedback loop for a product used by X customers; identified the top 3 support-driven feature requests that reduced ticket volume 20%
Taught English to 30 students	Designed and iterated a learning experience for 30 users with varying skill levels; measured progress, identified friction, and adjusted the product (curriculum) weekly
Ran operations for a restaurant chain	Managed end-to-end process optimization across 3 locations; reduced customer wait time 18% by redesigning the ordering flow based on staff and customer observation
Worked in healthcare as a nurse	Coordinated care across cross-functional teams under time pressure; primary user advocate in a system where patients rarely had a voice
Built and sold an Etsy store	Founded a consumer product business: defined the product, set pricing, managed customer feedback, shipped improvements based on reviews — all while managing supply chain constraints

THE LINE YOU MUST NOT CROSS

Translation is fine. Fabrication is not. You cannot say you "owned" a product you weren't responsible for, or claim metrics you don't have evidence of. Interviewers ask follow-up questions. If your story doesn't hold up to "tell me more about that number," it will hurt you more than the original experience would have. Be honest about what you contributed — and be bold about claiming the full value of that contribution.

KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 2

You don't have a gap on your resume. You have a different on-ramp to the same destination. The skills that make great PMs — empathy, communication,

decisions under ambiguity — are built in many careers. You just need to learn the vocabulary to make them visible.

EXERCISE 2

List 5 things you did in your previous career. For each one, write the PM translation using the framework above. Focus on: what was the user problem? What did you do? What was the measurable outcome? Then ask a working PM to review your translations for accuracy. LinkedIn is full of PMs who will give you 15 minutes of feedback if you ask directly.

MODULE 3

Building a Portfolio from Scratch

FRAMEWORKS

- Know exactly what goes in a PM portfolio (and what doesn't)
- Build at least one portfolio piece this week using the teardown format
- Understand how to use portfolio work to demonstrate thinking, not just output

What a PM portfolio is (and isn't)

A PM portfolio is not a design portfolio. You don't need beautiful mockups or Figma files. A PM portfolio is evidence of product thinking — specifically: how you identify problems, how you frame solutions, and how you make tradeoff decisions.

Nobody is hiring you to have opinions about products. They're hiring you to have structured opinions about products, backed by evidence, communicated clearly. The portfolio is how you show that before you're in the room.

The four portfolio piece types — choose two

1. Product teardown. Take a product you use daily. Write a 1-2 page analysis: what job is this product hired to do? Who is the primary user? Where does it delight them? Where does it fail them? What would you change, and why? This is the most universally applicable portfolio piece — most people write them at a surface level, so going deep is how you stand out.

2. Redesign concept. Pick a specific friction point in a product and propose a solution. This doesn't need polished design — a sketch, a wireframe, or a well-written spec is enough. What matters is the reasoning: why is this a problem worth solving? Why this solution over alternatives? What would you measure to know if it worked?

3. Original mini-PRD. Write a spec for a feature that doesn't exist yet. Keep it small — one feature, 2-3 user stories, clear acceptance criteria, and a success metric. This demonstrates spec writing, prioritization, and product thinking simultaneously.

4. Case study from your previous work. A structured story about a problem you solved that involved user needs, tradeoffs, and measurable outcomes. Even if it's not from a tech product role, this is often the most authentic and compelling portfolio piece.

The teardown template

PRODUCT TEARDOWN TEMPLATE — COPY AND USE

```
PRODUCT TEARDOWN: [Product Name]
Date: [Month Year] | Author: [Your Name]

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WHAT JOB IS THIS PRODUCT HIRED TO DO?
[One paragraph. Jobs-to-Be-Done framing:
"When [situation], users hire [product] to [job they're trying to do]"]

WHO IS THE PRIMARY USER?
[Be specific. Not "adults 25-45" — describe the actual person with the
actual problem. What are they trying to accomplish? What have they
already tried?]
```

```
[2-3 specific examples with detail. Why do these work? What design
or product decision made them work?]

WHERE DOES THE PRODUCT FAIL ITS USERS?
[2-3 specific friction points. What is the user trying to do, where
does the product let them down, and what is the cost of that failure?]

ONE IMPROVEMENT I WOULD PRIORITIZE
[Describe the problem to solve, the proposed solution, the success
metric, and the tradeoff — what you'd deprioritize to make room for this]

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE
[User reviews, App Store ratings, personal observation, cited research —
document what you referenced]
```

Where to host your portfolio

- **Notion:** Fastest to set up. Professional enough for most roles under director level.
- **Personal website:** Best for roles at product-forward companies. Shows initiative.
- **Google Docs (shared link):** Only if everything else is strong. Plain docs without context look unpolished.
- **PDF attached to your email:** Appropriate when reaching out to a specific person and you want to make it easy to forward.

KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 3

One deep portfolio piece beats five shallow ones. Your goal is to make a hiring manager think "I want to talk to this person about how they think" — not "this person has a lot of opinions." Depth, structure, and honest tradeoff reasoning are the signals they're looking for.

EXERCISE 3

Write a product teardown for the last app you complained about. Use the template above. Aim for 600-900 words. When you're done, ask yourself: does

this show how I think, or does it just show that I noticed problems? If it's the latter, go back and add the "One Improvement" section with a real prioritization argument.

MODULE 4

The Resume That Gets Past ATS

TEMPLATES

- Structure your resume for ATS systems AND human readers
- Write bullet points that show impact, not activity
- Customize the resume without rewriting it from scratch for every application

How ATS actually works

Applicant Tracking Systems are keyword-matching tools. They're looking for terms from the job description in your resume. For every role you apply to, your resume should include the specific words they used — not synonyms, not paraphrases. The exact words.

This sounds mechanical because it is. But it's also a 10-minute task, not a full rewrite. Pull the job description. Highlight the key responsibilities and required skills. Cross-reference with your resume. Add any missing terms that honestly describe your experience. Done.

The PM resume structure

RESUME STRUCTURE TEMPLATE

```
1. HEADER
   Name — Location — Phone — Email — LinkedIn — Portfolio URL

2. SUMMARY (recommended for career switchers)
   2-3 sentences. Explain why your non-traditional background is a
```

```
   feature, not a bug. Lead with your value, not your career history.
   Example: "Former [role] with 6 years of [transferable experience].
   [Measurable outcome]. Bringing [specific skill] to a PM role where
   [what you want to work on]."

3. EXPERIENCE (reverse chronological)
   Each role: Company | Title | Dates | Location
   3-5 bullet points per role using the impact formula below

4. SKILLS
   Keep it short. PM tools (Jira, Amplitude, Figma), methodologies
   (Agile, Scrum, user research), domain knowledge relevant to your
   target roles

5. EDUCATION
   Degree, school, year. Don't list GPA unless it's 3.8+.

6. PORTFOLIO / SIDE PROJECTS
   Link to your portfolio. Any PM-adjacent side projects with a
   one-line description of what you built and who it was for.
```

The impact bullet formula

Every resume bullet: **[Action verb] + [what you did] + [the measurable result]**. Most people write the first two parts and leave out the third. The third part is the only part the hiring manager cares about.

Activity bullet (weak)	Impact bullet (strong)
Worked with engineering team on new features	Led cross-functional delivery of 3 features per quarter; reduced time-to-launch 25% by standardizing the spec process
Conducted user research sessions	Ran 20 user interviews in 6 weeks; identified 3 friction points that became the next quarter's roadmap priorities, reducing support tickets 18%
Managed customer feedback process	Built and owned a feedback triage system processing 200+ monthly submissions; surfaced 2 features now in production
Created onboarding documentation	Redesigned onboarding documentation for 40+ enterprise clients; reduced time-to-first-value from 14 days to 6

Numbers you think you don't have

The common objection: "I don't have metrics from my previous job." You have more than you think:

- Team size you coordinated (people affected)
- Volume of work (orders processed, customers served, documents produced)
- Timeline compression (how much faster did you make something?)
- Scale (how many locations, channels, users, students?)
- Before/after comparison (what was the baseline? What changed?)

"Led onboarding for 3 enterprise clients representing $2M in ARR" is a number. "Managed curriculum for a Title I school district serving 800 students" is a number. Find the number.

KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 4

Your resume needs to do two jobs: survive ATS keyword matching, and make a human want to call you. Optimize for ATS with exact language from the job description. Optimize for humans with impact bullets that tell a clear story of what changed because you were there.

EXERCISE 4

Take your current resume and rewrite every bullet point using the impact formula. If you can't identify the measurable result for a bullet, cut it — it's not earning its space. Then paste a PM job description you're interested in and identify every keyword that isn't on your resume. Add the ones that honestly apply. This is your customized resume for that role.

MODULE 5

FRAMEWORKS

- Answer behavioral questions using the STAR method with PM-specific content
- Structure a product case study answer in under 10 minutes
- Prepare for the 5 most common PM interview scenarios

The two types of PM interviews

Behavioral interviews are about your past. "Tell me about a time you had to make a decision with incomplete information." "Describe a conflict with an engineer and how you resolved it." These are answered with the STAR method.

Case study / product design interviews are about your thinking. "Design a product for elderly users." "How would you improve our mobile app?" "A metric dropped 20% — walk me through how you'd diagnose it." These are answered with a structured framework.

Most PM interviews use both types. You need to prepare for both.

STAR method for PMs

S	**Situation:** 1-2 sentences of context. The product, the team, the moment. Keep it brief — the interviewer doesn't need the full backstory.
T	**Task:** What was your specific responsibility? What were you trying to accomplish or solve?
A	**Action:** What did YOU specifically do? Not "we" — "I." This is the most important part. Be specific about the steps, the reasoning, and the decisions you made.
R	**Result:** What happened? Include a metric if possible. If not, describe the qualitative outcome — and what you'd measure next time.

A full STAR example for a career switcher

Question: "Tell me about a time you had to balance competing priorities."

EXAMPLE ANSWER USING STAR

```
SITUATION: In my previous role as a customer success manager, I was
simultaneously responsible for onboarding three new enterprise clients
during Q4 — our busiest period — while also being asked to lead a process
audit that leadership wanted completed by year-end.

TASK: I needed to deliver all three onboardings on schedule (each
representing a significant first-year contract) while producing a
credible audit with real findings — not just a checklist.

ACTION: First, I mapped the time requirements for each. Audits could be
done in concentrated blocks; client work required distributed daily
attention. I batched audit work into Tuesday and Thursday afternoons
and blocked mornings for clients. I also negotiated a 2-week extension
on Client C's onboarding after their stakeholder became unavailable —
proactively, before it became a crisis.

RESULT: All three clients completed onboarding within the quarter.
Clients A and B on schedule; Client C 9 days late, communicated in
advance. The audit produced 7 findings, 3 of which were implemented
in Q1. My manager cited this in my performance review as an example
of operating at higher scope.
```

The product case study framework

When asked to design a product or diagnose a problem, use this structure:

1. **Clarify the goal.** "Before I jump in — are we optimizing for engagement, revenue, retention, or acquisition?" Always ask before you answer.
2. **Define the user.** "Let me pick a primary user segment and explain why." Describe that user with specificity — not a demographic, a situation and a job to be done.
3. **Identify the problem.** "What is the user trying to get done? What are the 3 biggest friction points in that job today?"
4. **Generate solutions.** "Here are 3 approaches with different tradeoffs." Showing that you generate options before committing is the signal interviewers want.

5. **Prioritize and justify.** "I'd prioritize [option] because [impact, feasibility, alignment with goals]."
6. **Define success.** "I'd measure success by [metric], and I'd want to see [benchmark] within [timeframe]."

The 5 most common PM interview questions

- **"Tell me about yourself."** Your 90-second story: where you came from, the through-line of your experience, why PM, why this company. Practice it until you can say it without thinking.
- **"What product would you improve and how?"** Pick one product you use every day. Have a prepared analysis using the teardown template. Don't say "I'd add AI." Go deeper.
- **"How do you decide what to build next?"** Describe your prioritization framework. Impact vs. effort. User pain intensity times frequency. Name the framework. Show you actually use it.
- **"Tell me about a product failure."** Pick something real. Show you understand what went wrong, take accountability without catastrophizing, and extract a lesson you applied later.
- **"Why do you want to be a PM?"** Don't say "I've always been interested in products." Say: "I spent X years doing Y, and the pattern I kept noticing was [insight]. I want to solve that type of problem full-time."

KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 5

PM interviews test product thinking, not product knowledge. The interviewers know more about their product than you do. What they're evaluating is: how do you structure a problem, how do you make decisions, and how do you communicate under pressure. STAR handles the behavioral side. The case framework handles the product side. Both require rehearsal.

EXERCISE 5

Record yourself answering each of the 5 common questions above. Watch it back with the sound off — your body language tells you something. Then listen

with the sound on. Where do you hedge, trail off, or use filler words? Those the moments where you haven't finished thinking through your answer. Go and get specific.

MODULE 6

Your First 90 Days as a PM

FRAMEWORKS

- Know what to prioritize in your first 30, 60, and 90 days
- Build a listening tour plan before your first day
- Avoid the 3 most common new PM mistakes

The impulse to prove yourself

Most new PMs make the same mistake: they try to produce too much, too fast. They propose roadmap changes in week two. They write a spec before understanding the codebase. They schedule customer interviews before knowing who the current customers are.

The pressure to justify the hiring decision is real. But the PMs who succeed in new roles — especially career switchers — almost always describe the same behavior in their first 90 days: they listened more than they talked, asked more than they answered, and waited to propose changes until they understood why things were the way they were.

The 30-60-90 day framework

Days 1-30: Listen

Run a listening tour

Read every existing spec and PRD

Attend every team ritual once

Shadow 3 customer interactions

Map all existing metrics

Write nothing public yet

Days 31-60: Contribute

Identify one small, scoped win

Write one complete user story

Share your learning doc with manager

Start facilitating meetings

Run 5 user interviews solo

Ask for one piece of feedback

Days 61-90: Own

Propose a prioritization hypothesis

Deliver one shipped thing

Build a stakeholder map

Define your success metrics

Identify your working style gaps

Set 90-day goals with manager

The listening tour

In your first two weeks, meet with every stakeholder you'll work with regularly. The goal is not to introduce yourself — it's to understand what they need, what frustrates them, and what they wish the PM role delivered that it currently doesn't.

Ask these five questions in every meeting:

1. What are you working on right now that you're most focused on?
2. What's the biggest thing slowing you down?
3. What do you wish a PM would do differently than PMs you've worked with before?
4. What do I need to understand about this product that isn't obvious from the outside?
5. Who else should I talk to in my first 30 days?

Take notes. Share a summary with each person after the meeting. This one behavior alone will differentiate you from 80% of new PMs.

The three mistakes to avoid

1. Proposing before understanding. "Have you considered just...?" is the new PM's most damaging habit. Every feature someone didn't build was a considered decision. You don't know why yet. Ask before you propose.

2. Over-documenting at the expense of shipping. Good process is invisible — it accelerates the work. If you're writing specs that slow down engineers, your process is bad. The goal is shared understanding, not documentation coverage.

3. Trying to own relationships that aren't yours yet. Trust with engineers, designers, and stakeholders is earned over time. Show up consistently, follow through on commitments, and stay curious. That's the relationship strategy that works.

> **WHAT "GOOD" LOOKS LIKE AT 90 DAYS**
>
> At 90 days, you should know: who the users are and what their top 3 problems are. What the team's working norms are. What the team is shipping this quarter and why. What success looks like for your role. And one thing you've improved — even something small. If you have those five things, you're ahead.

> **KEY TAKEAWAY — MODULE 6**

The first 90 days is not a grace period. It's your most information-dense window — a period where you can ask questions that would seem ignorant months in, and where every observation is fresh. Use it. You'll never see the product through a new user's eyes again.

EXERCISE 6 — CAPSTONE

Write your Day 1 plan. Assuming you start a PM role tomorrow: who are the first 8 people you'd schedule for your listening tour? What 3 documents would you ask to read first? What single question would you ask your manager before your first week is over? The specificity of your answer tells you how ready you actually are.

What's Next

You have everything you need to start. The portfolio template. The resume formula. The interview frameworks. The 90-day plan. The only thing left is doing it.

Start with one portfolio piece. Write the teardown. Then do the resume. Then apply to roles you're not perfectly qualified for — that's how you find out where your gaps actually are.

Once you're in a PM role, the AI-Augmented PM course will help you build the workflows that make you fast. And if you're building something of your own, the Founder's PM Playbook applies these skills to building a business.

> *"The PM role is learnable. It's not a talent. It's a practice. Show up, stay curious, follow through. The rest is reps."*
>
> — Gonzalo Aguilar

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